



Sent to:

May 1, 2026

Minister Tanya Fir
Alberta Music Commission
West Anthem
Joe Ceci, MLA

Open Letter: Alberta's Music Action Plan needs fiscal transparency, governance clarity and real music-industry investment

Dear Minister Fir, representatives of West Anthem, representatives of the Alberta Music Commission, and Mr. Ceci,

I am writing as a member of Alberta's music community who wants to see the Alberta Music Action Plan succeed. The plan gives the sector long-overdue recognition and identifies opportunities worth pursuing, but as published it raises serious questions about fiscal transparency, governance, implementation and whether Alberta is prepared to invest in music as an economic sector.

My concern is simple: Alberta's plan identifies real opportunities, but it does not yet provide the fiscal transparency, safeguarded governance, dedicated investment architecture or music-rights strategy required to turn its economic language into durable growth. The concern is not that coordination, data or a Commission are inherently bad. The concern is that those tools must be additive, transparent and backed by investment that reaches creators, music businesses and music infrastructure.

I am sharing this as an open letter because these questions affect artists, music businesses, venues, rights-holders and communities across Alberta, and they deserve a broader public conversation.

The Alberta Music Action Plan describes music as a major contributor to Alberta's economy, stating that the sector contributes more than \$2.5 billion to provincial GDP and supports more than 23,000 jobs across the province. The plan also states that Alberta's music industry generated an average of \$4.4 billion in total output since 2020. ^[1, pp. 5, 11] If Alberta is going to treat music as an economic driver, the province needs an economic-development strategy that matches that ambition.

There are ideas in the plan worth supporting. The proposed **Music Friendly program** could become a major asset for Alberta municipalities if it is built around practical tools: model bylaws, venue access, permitting reform, all-ages performance pathways, rehearsal-space access, tourism coordination, venue-preservation strategies and direct support for local music entrepreneurs. ^[1, p. 18] The proposed intersection between film and



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music could also be valuable if it leads to real sync opportunities, music-video incentives, recording-facility usage, score work and business-development pathways between Alberta artists, labels, producers and film-production companies. ^[1, p. 21]

However, the plan's strongest ideas are undermined by a larger mismatch between the scale of the economic language and the thinness of several proposed actions. The document describes music as a major economic industry, but many actions focus on communications work, data collection, directories, research, coordination and work within existing budget allocations. Those activities may be useful, but they are not substitutes for direct investment or sector-building programs. ^[1, pp. 18–22]

The clearest example is Priority 2: **“Maximize the economic impact of music entrepreneurs and businesses.”** The only action listed under that priority is improved music-industry data collection and performance measurement. ^[1, p. 18] Data collection may help government describe the industry, justify future budgets and measure outcomes, but it does not itself maximize the economic impact of artists, labels, producers, managers, venues, publishers, studios, promoters or music entrepreneurs. Data does not create careers. Data does not finance records. Data does not build companies. Data does not get Alberta music into film and television. Data does not replace investment.

Data is necessary for accountability. **But data collection is not an economic-development strategy.**

The largest red flag is Priority 3: **“Maintain dedicated provincial funding.”** The plan states that Alberta has invested an average of \$14.8 million per year since 2021, but the plan itself says this includes supporting Alberta-made music, increasing market access, supporting venues such as the National Music Centre and Winspear Centre, expanding educational and training support, and supporting individual artists, non-profit organizations, “sound recording agencies” and music festivals. ^[1, p. 8]

That may be a defensible aggregate number, but it does not appear to represent a clear, dedicated, direct music-industry development fund. Without disaggregation, the public cannot see how much funding actually reaches working artists, labels, producers, managers, music companies, venues, studios and export-ready entrepreneurs.

This is not just an inference from the Action Plan. In the March 19, 2025 Standing Committee transcript, Minister Fir explained that the ministry reviewed programs including the Alberta Foundation for the Arts, the Alberta Media Fund, community grants and the cultural industries branch, and found an average annual music-sector investment of about \$14.8 million. ^[3] In the March 11, 2026 Standing Committee transcript, the Minister also stated that the focus of the Action Plan “is not new spending” but optimizing and modernizing existing programs. ^[4] That makes fiscal transparency essential.

The launch materials also state that an additional \$800,000 in grants has been awarded to organizations including National Music Centre, Alberta Music and West Anthem to support early action. ^[2] These organizations may be appropriate partners, but this reinforces the need for transparency. The public should know the recipient-specific amounts, funding agreements, deliverables, reporting requirements, selection process and whether any portion of this launch funding reaches artists, music businesses or rights-holders directly.

The public deserves a full fiscal breakdown of these numbers. Please publish a year-by-year schedule showing every grant, contract, sponsorship, contribution agreement, consulting payment and transfer counted

toward the \$14.8 million or nearly \$15 million annual funding claim, as well as the additional \$800,000 in early-action grants. The schedule should identify the recipient, amount, program, project, selection process, funding source, deliverables and whether the payment supported direct-to-artist activity, labels or sound recording, venues, festivals, capital infrastructure, education, consulting, administration, institutional operations or other activity.

Without that breakdown, the phrase “maintain funding” is not meaningful. One of Alberta’s main direct music project funding streams remains heavily oversubscribed. In 2024–25, AFA Music Individual Project Funding supported 140 out of 397 eligible applications, with \$1,387,528.84 awarded.^[5] That means approximately 35.3 per cent of eligible applications were funded and approximately 64.7 per cent were not. AFA’s current Music Individual Project Funding provides up to \$18,000 for a specific music project, but AFA funding is not assured.^[6] This is not a picture of a sector with adequate direct support.

Another concern is the plan’s repeated reliance on “**existing budget allocations.**” Priority 3 says government will explore options to modernize funding to ensure existing budget allocations and funding programs have the most impact possible, and Priority 7 says government will research funding opportunities for music-sector initiatives while “working within existing budget allocations.”^[1, pp. 19, 22] That wording suggests that new administration, research and coordination could be funded by reallocating money rather than increasing the funding base. Alberta does not need more PDFs funded by the same limited dollars. Alberta needs new investment that reaches artists, producers, managers, labels, studios, music companies, venues and export-ready entrepreneurs.

At minimum, Alberta should commit to a **no-net-loss principle**: no existing direct artist, music-business or sector-development funding should be reduced to fund Commission administration, consulting, research, websites or reporting.

The plan also raises concerns about industry terminology and program design. The document refers to “sound recording agencies.”^[1, p. 8] The terminology question is not a gotcha; it is a signal that programs must be designed around the actual structure of the music sector. Alberta’s own Music Organization Operating Grant generally uses “sound recording organization,” and it defines eligibility around organizations that develop, produce, license, release, promote and distribute sound recordings as a principal business function. It also states that artist-run labels or artist-entrepreneurs are not eligible.^[7]

If the Action Plan means Alberta Media Fund-eligible sound recording organizations, it should say that. If it means record labels, it should say labels. If it means music businesses, it should define which kinds: labels, publishers, managers, distributors, studios, producers, promoters, booking agencies, artist-services companies, export companies, music supervisors or artist-owned businesses. Music is a rights-based business. A plan that uses imprecise terminology risks building imprecise programs.

The more serious version of that problem is the plan’s treatment of intellectual property. Music is not only an events, jobs or tourism sector. Music is an intellectual-property economy. A strong music industry depends on who owns the songs, who owns the masters, who administers the rights, who controls the metadata, who collects royalties, who can license works efficiently and who participates in long-term catalog value.

The Action Plan recognizes music publishing, SOCAN, sync opportunities and royalties in parts of the document and glossary, and it explicitly refers to “Albertan-created intellectual property” in Priority 6.1 in relation to film and television. ^[1, pp. 11, 21, 31] That is useful. But the plan does not treat music IP ownership, publishing capacity, master ownership, metadata, royalty collection, catalog development or rights administration as central strategic priorities, funding streams or performance measures.

That is a major strategic weakness.

This gap is especially notable because, during the launch event, Music Publishers Canada highlighted the opportunity to grow music publishing companies in Alberta, keep IP anchored locally and scale globally. ^[12] That is exactly the right ambition. But the written Action Plan does not yet translate that ambition into a dedicated publishing, copyright, royalty, metadata or catalog-development strategy.

A serious Alberta music strategy should address the music rights stack: publishing, master ownership, neighbouring rights, mechanical royalties, performance royalties, metadata, royalty accounting, copyright administration, one-stop licensing, catalog development, sync clearance and long-term catalog value. If Alberta wants a serious music economy, it must help creators and companies capture value after the performance, after the grant cycle and after the release.

I am also concerned about the proposed Alberta Music Commission. The Commission’s public mandate says it will support economic growth opportunities by “plugging into opportunities for artists, creators and producers,” and its stated goals include industry representation and advocacy, talent and investment attraction, showcasing Alberta, celebrating successes and cross-government collaboration. ^[8] Those goals may be useful, but they do not yet demonstrate a clear mandate to build music-sector infrastructure, support rights ownership, grow music companies, develop export capacity, preserve venues, or help Alberta creators retain and monetize intellectual property.

The Commission is described as being built on the model and framework of the Alberta Film Commission. ^[1, p. 23] Film and music can intersect, but they are not the same industry. Film policy often revolves around production attraction, tax credits, locations and crew infrastructure. Music policy must address intellectual property, publishing, master rights, touring, live venues, fan development, management, labels, recording, sync, digital platforms and artist-owned businesses.

The governance issue also needs to be clarified. In the March 19, 2025 Standing Committee transcript, Minister Fir referred to the possibility of establishing a music commission and commissioner role “within the department.” ^[3] In the March 11, 2026 transcript, she described the music commissioner as a “one-stop main contact,” similar to Alberta’s Film Commissioner. ^[4] If the Alberta Music Commission or Music Commissioner is housed within the department rather than established as an arm’s-length body, what safeguards will ensure independent industry advice, transparent decision-making, conflict disclosure and protection of existing artist and sector funding?

A music commission may be useful, but only if it is additive, transparent and led by people with direct music-industry expertise. It should not absorb funding from existing artist or sector supports. It should not duplicate Alberta Music. It should not centralize industry advocacy inside government without clear safeguards, open reporting and independent industry input.

Given the number of overlapping organizations involved in strategy development, public funding, grant administration, venues, sector advocacy and proposed implementation, the Commission must also be designed to avoid any perception of a closed-loop funding and policy ecosystem. That means public disclosure of budgets, contracts, conflicts, recusals, advisory roles, selection processes and recipient relationships.

Before the Commission proceeds further, the public should receive answers in four areas:

1. **Fiscal transparency:** What is the Commission's annual operating budget? Is that budget new money or reallocated from existing arts or music funding? Will the province publish the full \$14.8 million or nearly \$15 million annual funding schedule, plus the additional \$800,000 in early-action grants, by recipient, amount, program, source, selection process and deliverable? What portion of the early-action funding directly supports artists, music businesses or rights-holders?
2. **Governance and safeguards:** What is the Commission's legal status? Is it arm's length from government, or housed within the department? Who appoints its leadership? How will conflicts of interest be disclosed and managed? Will it publish annual reports with measurable outcomes? Will it administer funding, recommend funding or only coordinate policy?
3. **Relationship to existing organizations:** What is the Commission's relationship to Alberta Music, West Anthem, National Music Centre, the Alberta Foundation for the Arts, the Alberta Media Fund, municipalities and existing funders? What safeguards will ensure that it does not duplicate, displace or weaken existing arm's-length sector organizations?
4. **Representation and expertise:** How will working artists, producers, managers, labels, publishers, rural communities, Indigenous creators, women, underrepresented communities and independent music businesses be represented? Will the Commission include expertise in publishing, master rights, neighbouring rights, metadata, royalty accounting, sync licensing and catalog administration? What role will it play in helping Alberta creators and companies retain, administer and monetize intellectual property?

Alberta should also benchmark itself against other provinces. British Columbia's Amplify BC is a dedicated music fund supporting B.C. artists, live music presenters and music companies, with program areas including Music Industry Initiatives, Record in BC, Career Development, Live Music, Demo Recording, Business Foundations and Music Company support. The Province of British Columbia committed \$22.5 million over three years to Amplify BC in 2023, extending the province's music funding programs until 2027. ^[9] Manitoba Film & Music has a clear suite of music programs supporting local musicians and music businesses, including Produce, Promote, Perform, Build and Indigenous: IMPACT programs. ^[10] Alberta does have music-related funding, including Alberta Media Fund/Cultural Industry Grants for some organizations involved in sound recording, but the current Action Plan does not yet show a comparable dedicated, multi-stream music-industry investment architecture. ^[11]

If Alberta wants music to be an economic sector, it needs economic tools. At minimum, implementation should include:

- a dedicated, multi-year Alberta music industry fund;
- increased direct artist project funding;
- music company, label, publisher and artist-management development support;

- publishing administration, metadata and rights-management support;
- master-rights and catalog-development programs;
- tour, export and market-access funding;
- sync-readiness, music-supervision and one-stop licensing programs;
- recording, producer and studio incentives;
- music-video funding that benefits artists and rights holders, not only film-production companies;
- venue preservation, small-room support and rehearsal-space access;
- municipal Music Friendly implementation grants;
- rural and small-city music infrastructure support;
- clear KPIs tied to artist income, company revenue, royalties, export revenue, sync placements, touring activity, private leverage, business growth, catalog development, IP ownership, venue access and rural, Indigenous and equity outcomes.

I support the goal of strengthening Alberta music. I support a Music Friendly program if it is built correctly. I support connecting music with film, tourism and municipalities. But the current plan does not yet match its own economic rhetoric. It risks creating another layer of coordination without solving the underlying problem: **Alberta's music industry is undercapitalized, and the plan does not yet treat intellectual property, rights administration and catalog value as foundations of music-sector economic growth.**

I respectfully request a written public response within 30 days addressing: the fiscal breakdown behind the \$14.8 million or nearly \$15 million annual funding claim; the additional \$800,000 in early-action grants; whether Commission funding is new or reallocated; the Commission's operating budget, authority and governance structure; the safeguards that will protect existing artist and sector funding; and how Alberta will address intellectual property, catalog value and rights administration as central pillars of music-sector economic growth.

The province should not proceed with implementation that reallocates existing funding into administration until it publishes the full fiscal picture, clarifies the Commission's governance, corrects terminology and builds a real music-industry investment strategy.

Alberta does not need a strategy that is difficult to audit.

Alberta needs a serious, transparent and properly funded music-industry development plan that helps creators and music companies build long-term value in Alberta.

Sincerely,



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Sources

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